

AdaL Fresh-User Friction Log

First-Time Developer Experience Audit

Date: April 12, 2026 • Evaluator: Kumail Raza • Starting Point: sylph.ai

Executive Summary

AdaL has a strong product with real competitive advantages (model switching, local-first, auto-prompting). But the path from "I heard about AdaL" to "I'm using AdaL" has critical gaps that cost users at every step.

Biggest Finding: A developer who lands on sylph.ai today cannot figure out how to try AdaL for free within 2 minutes. The free trial — your most powerful conversion tool — is invisible.

Step 1: Discovery / Landing Page (sylph.ai)

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
First Impression	Clean, modern design. Hero text "Bringing ideas to life for developers worldwide" is generic — doesn't say what AdaL is. A developer landing here for the first time doesn't know if this is an IDE, a CLI, a library, or a SaaS platform.	Medium	Lead with a one-liner: "AI coding agent that runs locally, switches models mid-session, and learns your codebase."
Value Prop Clarity	The three pillars (Architecture/Privacy/Interface) are good but buried in abstract cards. The killer feature — /model mid-session switching — is below the fold.	Medium	Move the model switching demo + /model command above the fold. It's your #1 differentiator.
CTA Visibility	"TRY ADAL" button is in the nav bar (good) but the primary hero area has no CTA at all. The hero section is purely brand messaging.	Medium	Add a primary CTA in the hero with curl install command and a "Get started in 2 minutes" button.
Free Trial / Pricing Clarity	CRITICAL: Pricing section shows only paid plans — \$20, \$100, \$200/month. No mention of a free trial, free credits, or free tier. LinkedIn posts mention "\$5 free credits" and "7-day trial" but neither appears on the landing page.	Critical	Add free tier/trial prominently: "Start free — 7-day trial, no credit card required" above paid plans. Highest-impact change.
Trust Signals	"World-Class Background" section with NVIDIA, Meta AI, Stanford, USC, UT	Good	Consider adding user count or

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
	Austin, MIT logos is strong. AdalFlow open-source mention is good.		GitHub stars for social proof.
Install Command	The install command (npm i -g @sylphai/adal-cli) does NOT appear on the landing page. Quickstart uses a different command. LinkedIn posts still reference the npm command. Which one should a user use?	Critical	Pick ONE primary install command and make it prominent. The curl command is now recommended — update LinkedIn posts and landing page to match.
Docs Link	Nav bar links to docs.sylph.ai (correct), but sylph.ai/docs returns a 404 page. Old bookmarks hit a dead end.	Critical	Add a redirect from sylph.ai/docs → docs.sylph.ai. Dead URLs kill trust.

Step 1 Verdict: A new user leaves the landing page thinking "looks cool, but costs \$20/month minimum." They never discover the free trial. Conversion lost.

Step 2: Documentation / Quickstart (docs.sylph.ai)

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
Findability (SEO)	docs.sylph.ai is a separate subdomain. Google search for "adal cli quickstart" indexes the quickstart page correctly. However, the main landing page links to "Docs" generically — no direct "Quickstart" link in main nav.	Medium	Add "Quickstart" as a direct nav item on sylph.ai. Reduce clicks to value.
Quickstart Quality	The quickstart at docs.sylph.ai/getting-started/quickstart is solid: 3 clear steps (Install → Launch → Try It), terminal commands, essential commands table, keyboard shortcuts.	Good	This is one of the strongest pages. Keep it.
First Terminal Command	Step 1 gives the curl install command — clean, copy-pasteable. npm tab alternative is also offered.	Good	No change needed.
Expected Output Shown?	After running adal, the docs say "First run opens browser for authentication, then you're ready" — but don't show what terminal output actually looks like. What does the user see?	Medium	Add a screenshot or terminal output block showing what a successful first launch looks like.
Step 3: "Try It"	Shows three example prompts. Decent but generic. Doesn't showcase the killer feature (model switching).	Medium	Add a "Wow moment" example: demonstrate AdaL's power in 30 seconds. Show /model switching

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
			output. User needs to feel impressed, not just onboarded.
Error Handling Guidance	No troubleshooting section. What if install fails? What if the adal command isn't found? Common first-run failures have no guidance.	Medium	Add a "Common Issues" section: PATH not set, Node version requirements, auth timeout, firewall blocking.
Prerequisites	The quickstart doesn't list prerequisites. Does AdaL need Node.js? What version? A user on an older system will hit errors with no explanation.	Medium	Add a "Prerequisites" section: OS requirements, Node version (if npm), network requirements for auth.

Step 2 Verdict: The quickstart itself is good once you find it. The problem is the journey to the quickstart has friction (no direct link from landing page, 404 on sylph.ai/docs).

Step 3: Installation / First Run

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
Install Command Clarity	Two install methods exist: native curl (recommended) and npm. LinkedIn posts still reference npm as primary method. Inconsistency across channels.	Medium	Standardize messaging: if curl is now recommended, update all external references.
Authentication Flow	"First run opens browser for authentication" — friction point for users in terminal-only environments (SSH, headless servers, CI). Token-based alternative not mentioned.	Medium	Document alternative auth methods or clearly state "requires a desktop environment with a browser for initial setup."
First Success Moment	After auth, the user types a prompt and gets a response. But there's no guidance on what a "good first prompt" looks like. Examples don't showcase model switching.	Medium	Add: "Try this: type /model to switch to Gemini, then ask it to design a landing page. See how different models have different strengths."

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
Time to First Value	Estimated ~4–5 minutes (install + auth + first prompt). Docs claim "2 minutes" — optimistic but reasonable for experienced devs.	Minor	Claim is approximately accurate. No change needed.
Cost Transparency	After auth, how does a new user know how much they're spending? Credit balance? Token usage? Especially important since the landing page shows only \$20+/month plans.	Medium	Show credit balance in the CLI UI or on first launch: "You have X credits remaining. Usage: Y tokens this session."

Step 3 Verdict: Installation is smooth if you follow the quickstart. The gap is that most users never reach the quickstart because the landing page doesn't convert them.

Step 4: Core Feature Discovery

Aspect	Observation	Severity	Recommendation
Model Switching (/model)	AdaL's biggest differentiator. Well-documented in the quickstart commands table. But it's treated as just another command, not as THE reason to use AdaL.	Medium	Elevate this in docs: dedicated "Model Switching" tutorial page with cost comparisons and use-case recommendations.
Deep Research	Available via Tab toggle. Mentioned in docs navigation. But no "try this now" prompt in the quickstart.	Medium	Add to quickstart: "Press Tab twice to enter Deep Research mode. Try: 'Research the best auth libraries for Node.js'"
Auto-Prompting	The landing page mentions "auto-prompting — our research breakthrough" but the docs don't explain what this means or how to see it in action.	Medium	Add an "Auto-Prompting Explained" doc page. Users should understand what makes AdaL learn their codebase.
Worktree Management	Documented in quickstart. Nice feature for parallel branch work.	Good	No change needed.

Cross-Cutting Issues

Issue	Severity	Evidence	Recommendation
sylph.ai/docs returns 404	Critical	Fetches the URL — returns "404 Oops! Page not found". Docs live at docs.sylph.ai but the intuitive URL is broken.	Redirect sylph.ai/docs → docs.sylph.ai
sylph.ai/careers not indexable	Critical	Careers page is SPA-rendered. Google sees only the shell HTML. Job listings are invisible to search engines. The hiring post (167 reactions) drives traffic to a page that doesn't render for bots.	Server-side render the careers page, or add a static HTML fallback with job listings.
Inconsistent install commands	Medium	Landing page: no install command. Quickstart: curl (recommended) + npm. LinkedIn: npm i -g @sylphai/adal-cli. Three different entry points, three different instructions.	Standardize on ONE primary command everywhere.
Inconsistent trial/pricing messaging	Critical	LinkedIn posts mention "\$5 free credits" (older) and "7-day trial" (newer). Landing page shows only \$20/\$100/\$200 paid plans. No free option visible. Quickstart doesn't mention cost at all.	Unify messaging: if there's a free trial, it must be the most prominent thing on the landing page AND in the quickstart.
No comparison content on site	Medium	"Why AdaL vs Copilot/Cursor/Claude Code?" is answered in LinkedIn posts but not on the website. Competitive benchmark data exists but isn't published.	Add a comparison page: /compare or /vs-copilot. This type of content gets the highest LinkedIn engagement.

Summary

Critical Issues — Fix Immediately

1. Free trial is invisible — Landing page shows only paid plans. The #1 conversion killer.
2. sylph.ai/docs returns 404 — Broken URL kills trust and loses users.

3. Careers page not indexable — Hiring post sends 167 people to a page Google can't read.
4. Inconsistent trial/pricing messaging — "\$5 credits" vs "7-day trial" vs "\$20/month" across channels.

Medium Issues — Fix Soon

5. Hero text doesn't explain what AdaL is — generic "Bringing ideas to life."
6. No install command on the landing page — users don't know how to start.
7. No expected output/screenshots in quickstart — users can't confirm success.
8. No troubleshooting section — common first-run failures have no guidance.
9. Model switching (killer feature) is buried, not elevated.
10. No comparison page on the website.

What's Working Well

11. Quickstart structure is solid (3 clear steps, commands, shortcuts).
12. Copy-paste terminal commands work well.
13. Trust signals (team background, open source) are strong.
14. Worktree management docs are clear.

Metrics

Metric	Result
Time to find install command	~3 min (had to navigate to docs.sylph.ai, not found on landing page)
Time to first successful output	~5 min (estimated, includes auth)
Number of dead ends	2 (sylph.ai/docs 404, no free trial path)

Metric	Result
Number of tab/site switches needed	3 (sylph.ai → docs.sylph.ai → auth browser)
Would a new user give up?	YES — at pricing. A user who doesn't know about the free trial sees \$20/month minimum and bounces.

Severity Guide

Level	Meaning
Critical	User gives up or gets stuck. Directly blocks adoption.
Medium	User is confused or slowed down. Damages confidence.
Good / Minor	Suboptimal but doesn't block progress, or works well.

Prepared by Kumail Raza | April 2026 | Methodology: Fresh-user walkthrough with no prior product knowledge assumed.